

Dandelion vs. Orchid CHILDREN



What is Temperament?

Temperament is an in-born way of responding to the world. It includes how sensitive, reactive and adaptive we are – emotionally, physically and socially. Think of it as the child's operating system.

DANDELION KIDS

- Resilient in the soil.
- Can thrive in a wide variety of environments.
- Less sensitive to stress, praise or change.
- Lower emotional reactivity.



ORCHID KIDS

- Delicate but uniquely beautiful in the right conditions.
- Highly sensitive to both positive and negative environments .
- Thrive in nurturing, supportive settings.
- Struggle more in high-stress or chaotic environments.

ORCHID KIDS	DANDELION KIDS
Higher sensitivity	Lower sensitivity
More reactive	Less reactive
Less flexible; needs more — routine/support	More flexible with change of routine and support

The Role of the HPA Axis (Stress System)

- Built-in alarm (threat) system.
- Release cortisol (stress hormone).
- Gets us ready to fight, flight freeze.

When the environment is stressful and unpredictable, a child's stress response may stay on too long, leading to mental health concerns .

There's No "Gene for Anxiety or Depression"



Contrary to myth, there is no single gene that causes mental health disorders. What research shows is gene-environment interaction: some kids are more biologically sensitive to their environment and can develop chronic stress patterns if settings are harsh. Boyce and Ellis (2005) found that preschool children with high biological sensitivity—measured by cortisol and stress responses—struggled more in chaotic environments but thrived exceptionally in supportive ones, while less sensitive children remained stable across environments, demonstrating that sensitivity acts as a plasticity factor rather than a vulnerability.

